

**A COMPREHENSIVE ANALYSIS OF INVESTMENT
PREFERENCE AMONG THE GENERATIONS IN USA
FOCUS ON GENERATION 'Z'**

Submitted in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the degree of

Master of Business Administration (Online MBA)

by

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VIT Online Learning Program

DECLARATION

I, **Vijayalakshmi Ravi** with register number **23EMBA1052** hereby declare that the project report entitled “**A Comprehensive Analysis of Investment Preference Among the Generations in USA: Focus on Generation ‘Z’**” submitted by me to MBA VIT Online learning program, Vellore, in partial fulfillment of the requirement for the award of the degree of **Master of Business Administration** is a bonafide work carried out by me under the supervision of **Prof. Dr. Rajesh Mamilla**, Professor, Department of Business, VIT Business School, VIT Vellore – 632 014.

I further declare that the work reported in this project has not been submitted and will not be submitted, either in part or in full, for the award of any other degree or diploma in this institute or any other Institute or University.

Place: VIT VELLORE

Date: 28/12/2025

VIJAYALAKSHMI RAVI

Signature of the Candidate

CERTIFICATE

This is to certify that the project work entitled “**A Comprehensive Analysis of Investment Preference Among the Generations in USA: Focus on Generation ‘Z’**” submitted by **Vijayalakshmi Ravi** with registration number **23EMBA1052**, to VIT Vellore, in partial fulfillment of the requirement for the award of the degree of **Master of Business Administration**, is a bonafide work carried out by him/her under my supervision. The project fulfills the requirement as per the regulations of VIT Vellore and in my opinion meets the necessary standards for submission. The contents of this report have not been submitted and will not be submitted either in part or in full, for the award of any other degree or diploma in this Institute or any other Institute or University.

Place : VIT VELLORE

Date :

Guide Name & Signature

Examiner 1:

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Examiner 2:

Director, VITOL

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ABSTRACT

Generation 'Z' is starting to participate in the investment landscape with behaviors and preferences that significantly differ from those of previous generations. They are influenced by digital technology, social media, and economic uncertainty. Gen-Z investors often prefer non-traditional platforms and assets, showing less reliance on long-term financial planning. However, there is limited research about Gen-Z investing their investment approaches. The primary objective of this study is to thoroughly explore and gain deeper insights into the financial behaviors of Gen-Z individuals who engage in investment activities. Additionally, It seeks to discuss their asset allocation strategies with those of earlier generations, especially Generation-X and Millennials/ Generation-Y. By examining these differences, the study aims to illuminate the unique financial priorities and decision-making processes that characterize Gen-Z, shedding light on how their experiences and values shape their approach to investing in today's dynamic economic landscape. This study utilizes a secondary data analysis approach, using survey data from quantitative questionnaires provided by FINRA (Financial Industry Regulatory Authority) with a focus on the Southern Region of the United States. It also employs a dual approach to analysis, intertwining qualitative descriptions with quantitative data to explore the intricacies of Gen-Z investing in financial markets and how their approach is different from older generations.

Keywords: Generation-Z, investment behavior, financial priorities, asset allocation strategies, decision making process.

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CHAPTER – 1

INTRODUCTION

1.1 Introduction to Research Study

Generation Z has become a key demographic as global financial markets change. This is especially true in developed countries like the U.S., where they are becoming more involved in the financial sector. This engagement is driven by the fast growth of financial technology, the power of social media, and a stronger focus on being financially independent. Gen Z is a big part of the financial market, even though more and more young people are getting involved, many young investors still make unplanned investment choices, social factors are external influences from society and the environment that impact an individual's attitudes, behaviors, and decisions. Essentially, they are elements of a person's social context that can influence their thoughts, actions, or choices. (Elango, Ajah, & Shah, 2023).

Generation Z (born between 1997 and 2010) is emerging not only as the consumers of tomorrow but also as the investors of today. This is happening in a time when technology is changing quickly, and everyone can access financial markets. Even though many members of Generation Z are still new to the job market, they are already making risky financial choices by investing in stocks, cryptocurrencies, and digital assets. A survey by the CFA Institute and FINRA found that 56% of U.S. Gen Z (ages 18–25) say they own at least some investments. Meanwhile, global trends show a change: 30% of Generation Z start investing in their early 20s, which is faster than older generations. This indicates a significant shift toward early investment participation among Generation Z. (CFA Institute & FINRA Investor Education Foundation, 2023)

U.S. Bank conducted an online survey in partnership with Edelman Dxl from May 12 to May 24, 2023, involving 3,000 active investors across the United States and 1,000 aspiring investors. Sixteen percent of respondents identified as Generation Z (ages 18-26). Younger generations are navigating inflation, high interest rates, and elevated prices; however, they also inherit a markedly different world compared to older generations. Since 1980:

- Generation Z perceives wealth differently than previous generations and is willing to sacrifice investment returns to support causes they believe in.
- Over 75% of young investors report that social media simplifies the perception of investing.
- Half of all investors feel overwhelmed and are more pessimistic than in the previous year. These investors are passionate about investing in causes they believe in and are actively seeking financial guidance. (U.S Bank Survey, 2023).

1.2 Purpose and scope of this study

This study focuses on Generation Z individuals living in the Southern region of the United States. This research study aims to contribute to this evolving discourse by proposing a model that links influencing factors (e.g., digital media exposure, attitudes towards investing, and investment intentions (goals), on to actual investing behavior (or the lack thereof), and culminating in asset allocation decisions. Demographic information is collected to provide a clearer understanding of the respondents and to support interpretation of their behavioral patterns.

By examining these dynamics specifically within Gen Z, this study aims not only to deepen academic knowledge but also to guide financial educators, fintech platforms, and policymakers who seek to empower a generation that holds great potential—and faces distinctive challenges—in the economic landscape. Understanding these factors helps in creating effective financial education, regulation, tools, and products tailored

to their needs—thus enhancing market stability, inclusivity, and long-term wealth outcomes.

1.3 Research Gap And Contribution Of The Study

The most previous reports such as the FINRA 2023 and U.S bank 2023 have looked at Generation Z's investment behavior nationally. This study addresses that regional gap by focusing specifically on Generation Z investors in the Southern United States.

The Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB) is used in this study to analyze how Gen Z investors make decisions. The relationship between attitude, subjective norms, perceived behavioral control, and behavioral intention leading to actual behavior is the traditional focus of TPB. The TPB model has been used to study how young adults invest in various countries but there is no research has applied the Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB) to Generation Z's investment behavior which necessitates drawing international work such as the Oman-based TPB study by Pandurugan,V., & Al Shammakhi, B.N.S in 2024), which primarily focused on investment intention of Generation Z. So, this study looks at young investors in the US, narrowing the focus to a particular place. However, by adding asset allocation as a novel behavioral outcome that follows actual investment behavior, the present study expands on the TPB model. The TPB framework's explanatory power in the context of investment behavior is increased by the inclusion of asset allocation. By examining these outcomes, this study seeks to close both the regional and theoretical gaps, which offers deeper insights into how investors allocate their investments after deciding to invest.

1.4 Research Objectives

1. To examine the relationship between influencing factor (social media) and attitudes towards investing.
2. To assess how attitudes towards investing affect investment goals (intentions) among Generation-Z investors.
3. To examine the relationship between attitudes towards investing and actual investment behavior among Generation Z investors.
4. To examine the relationship between influencing factor (social media) and investing behavior.
5. To evaluate whether investment goals (intentions) lead to actual investment behavior.
6. To determine how investment behavior influences asset allocation decisions among Generation-Z investors.
7. To analyze the investment behavior of Gen Z investors.
8. To examine the preference of Generation Z investors toward different investment avenues such as cryptocurrency, stocks, mutual funds, NFTs, and ETFs.

1.5 Key variables of the study

1. Investing Attitude – How Generation Z feels and thinks about investing; this shapes their goals and how they act when investing.
2. Goal – Financial or investment targets; these are shaped by their attitude and influence how they actually invest.
3. Actual Investment Behavior – The real actions people take when investing; this is influenced by their attitude and goals, and affects how they spread their money across different assets.
4. Influencing Factors – Things like how much they know about money or it represents an external factor that may influence other variables.

5. Asset Allocation – How investments are spread out among different types of assets; this is affected by actual investment behavior.

1.5 Hypothesis

1. H₁- Investing attitude has a significant relationship with Goal.
2. H₂- Investing attitude has a significant relationship with actual investment behavior.
3. H₃- Influencing factors have a significant relationship with investing attitude.
4. H₄- Influencing factors have a significant relationship with investing behavior.
5. H₅- Goal significant relationship with actual investment behavior.
6. H₆- Actual investment behavior has a relationship with the asset allocation, such as crypto, stocks, mutual fund, NFTs, and ETFs among Generation Z investors.

CHAPTER – 2

REVIEW OF LITERATURE

A literature review is a systematic and comprehensive examination and critical evaluation of published scholarly works, such as academic books, peer-reviewed journal articles, extensive reports, and reputable online studies, that directly relate to a specific research topic or field of inquiry. Its primary purpose is to identify existing knowledge and inconsistencies within the current literature, thereby establishing a solid theoretical and contextual foundation for the new study and guiding subsequent research directions.

2.1 The Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB)

The Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB), created by Ajzen in 1991, is a commonly used model for understanding and predicting how people act. According to TPB, a person's intention to perform a behavior is based on three main factors: their attitude toward the behavior, the subjective norms they feel, and their perception of how easy or hard it is to carry out the behavior. Attitude shows how someone personally feels about doing the behavior, subjective norms show the pressure they feel from others, and perceived behavioral control shows how they think the behavior will be easy or difficult for them. TPB has been used in many areas, like investment and financial choices, showing how beliefs and social influences affect people's plans to act. Ajzen (2014) pointed out that the Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB) is very flexible. This means researchers can use it in new or developing areas of behavior without changing its main ideas. They can also add other important factors, like past actions or moral standards, without affecting the core of the theory. This adaptability makes TPB a strong and useful tool for understanding and predicting many different kinds of behavior today. In the case of investing, asset allocation—deciding how to spread money across various financial options—is an example of a modern behavior that fits into this theory.

2.2 Investing Attitude

Attitudes refers to a person's overall evaluation or feeling about a particular object, idea, person, or situation, which can range from positive to negative. This concept encompasses various dimensions such as beliefs, emotions, and behavioral tendencies that influence an individual's attitude. For example, a person's attitude towards voting may be shaped by their beliefs about the importance of civic participation, their emotional response to political issues, and their past experiences with elections. (Ajzen 1985).

2.3 Investing at a Young Age

According to a survey conducted in 2022 and published by the FINRA Investor Education Foundation and CFA Institute (2023), 56% of U.S. Generation Z adults aged 18-25 hold some form of investment. These investments include stocks, bonds, mutual funds, and other financial instruments, highlighting a significant engagement with personal finance early in adulthood.

Generation Z starting to invest at an earlier age compared to previous generations. Data from a 2024 survey by Charles Schwab reveals that Gen Z began investing at an average age of 19. Gen Zers express strong optimism about their financial futures, with 60% feeling they are in a better position to achieve financial goals than previous generations with easier access to investing and more diverse investment options. This trend suggests a shift toward greater financial literacy and access to investment tools among younger people. This early investment behavior could have a substantial impact on long-term wealth accumulation. (Charles Schwab & Co., Inc., 2024)

2.4 Generation Z and Cryptocurrency Investment

The growth of cryptocurrency has likely encouraged many U.S. Gen Z investors to begin their investment journey. According to the FINRA Investor Education

Foundation 2023, 19% of them said they started by investing in crypto or non-fungible tokens (NFTs).

Crypto remains the top asset class among U.S. Gen Z investors, with 55% holding some form of cryptocurrency. Additionally, crypto is the most favored investment among millennials, whereas Gen X tends to prefer mutual funds and individual stocks. (CFA Institute & FINRA Investor Education Foundation, 2023)

According to the JPMorgan Chase Institute, 17% of active Chase checking account holders invested in crypto assets between January 2017 and May 2025, and approximately 20% of these investors transferred at least one month's take-home pay into crypto accounts. Younger generations exhibit higher participation rates in both direct cryptocurrency holdings and in ETFs that track crypto assets. Moreover, the expansion of exchange-traded products linked to cryptocurrencies has likely encouraged individuals who previously had no direct market exposure to participate (Wheat & Eckerd, 2025).

2.5 Goal/ Intention

Behavioral Intention is a concept in psychology that shows how much a person wants or is ready to do a certain action. According to the Theory of Planned Behavior, intention is the best sign of what a person will actually do. It shows how hard someone is willing to try to carry out the behavior, and it is influenced by their beliefs, what others think, and how much control they feel they have over the action. (Ajzen, 1991)

Gen Z people who invest are focused on financial goals that involve planning, like saving for unexpected costs and retirement. Their top three goals include having enough money for travel or vacations, saving for unexpected expenses, and being able to retire when they want and live comfortably. "Although retirement may still be many

years away, Gen Z investors are already beginning to view it as a current and intentional financial goal. (CFA Institute & FINRA Investor Education Foundation, 2023)

Time plays a vital role in retirement investing for Generation Z because beginning to save early enables investments to grow through compound interest. For instance, a Gen Z individual contributing \$5,000 each year with a 7% return starting at age 19 could reach more than \$1.5 million by age 65, whereas starting at age 25 would result in about \$998,000. (CNBC, 2024).

2.6 Financial and Investing Behavior

Financial behavior refers to how individuals manage and control their money, encompassing actions such as budgeting, spending, saving, and investment decisions. It examines whether people make rational financial choices based on logical analysis or are influenced by psychological factors like emotions, cognitive biases, and impulse control. Discussions often focus on the balance between personal decision-making autonomy and external influences from parental guidance or societal norms, as well as the role of inherent traits like risk tolerance and financial literacy versus environmental factors such as economic conditions and cultural background in shaping money behavior. (Thaler & Sunstein, 2008).

Financial behavior is a key part of understanding all choices at the personal, family, local, and country levels, showing how these choices will affect things and helping to make smart money decisions to help plan for spending or saving (Ahmad et al., 2019).

East, R.(1993) used the planned behavior idea to explain investment picks, showing that feelings, common social rules, and feeling in control of behavior are strongly linked with investment plans. The effects from friends, family, and how easy it is to get money are seen as strong things that change money behaviors.

Investment behavior, a multifaceted concept in finance, has attracted substantial scholarly interest. Montier defines it as the choices and actions made by individuals and institutional investors in response to market opportunities and risks, involving the allocation of financial resources. (Montier 2007).

According to the FINRA Foundation and CFA Institute (2023), survey from 2022, Gen Z investors tend to be confident, risk-tolerant, and heavily influenced by digital and social media platforms. Many invest out of curiosity, a desire for financial independence, or FOMO (fear of missing out), often relying on online sources, peers, and family for guidance. Conversely, non-investors in Gen Z usually avoid investing due to factors like low income, lack of savings, or limited financial knowledge. They tend to have less confidence in making financial decisions and fear losing money more, which discourages market participation. Overall, investors are proactive and tech-savvy, while non-investors tend to be more cautious and financially constrained.

2.7 Investment behavior post covid:

Gen Z is coming out of the pandemic with a stronger focus on saving money, becoming financially independent, gaining life experiences, and looking for financial education that they didn't have access to in school or their communities. This is based on new research from Bank of America's Better Money Habits report, which looks at what this generation (ages 18 to 24) sees as their biggest financial challenges and how they're working to take control of their money.

"As Gen Z starts their financial and career journeys, we're seeing a lot of motivation and positive actions toward building a strong financial base," said Christine Channels, Head of Community Banking and Client Protection at Bank of America.

"At the same time, there's a clear need for more financial education. Through our Better Money Habits platform, we're dedicated to helping these young adults find the

resources and support they need to build financial skills and overcome the obstacles in their path.” (Bank of America, 2021).

2.8 Influence of social media on financial advice

According to DataReportal (2024), 239 million Americans use social media regularly. The most popular internet platforms are Facebook and YouTube, and more than half of all American adults use Instagram.

TikTok, LinkedIn, Twitter, and Reddit are used by fewer people, mostly by younger people (Dimock, M. Pew Research Center 2024).

Many studies show that people rely on social media to find information that helps them make decisions (Cooley and Parks-Yancy 2019; Gupta 2019). Also, research shows that social media is increasingly affecting people’s financial choices. (Florendo and Estelami 2019)

Surprisingly, 79% of Americans in the Gen Z age groups get financial advice from social media (Forbes 2023).

For financial and investing information, Gen Z investors mostly rely on social media and online searches. Compared to millennial and Gen X investors, they rely more on social media and their families for information. Additionally, compared to Gen X and millennials, they are more likely to rely on financial apps and influencers for information. (FINRA 2023, survey from 2022)

Social media now serves as a significant channel for financial information, with younger generations relying on it more heavily than older adults. Young adults, in particular, consume financial content on these platforms at notably higher rates. TikTok, for example, has rapidly become a prominent source of financial insights for many in this age group (Akana, Lee, & Santucci, 2025).

2.9 Demographic Factor

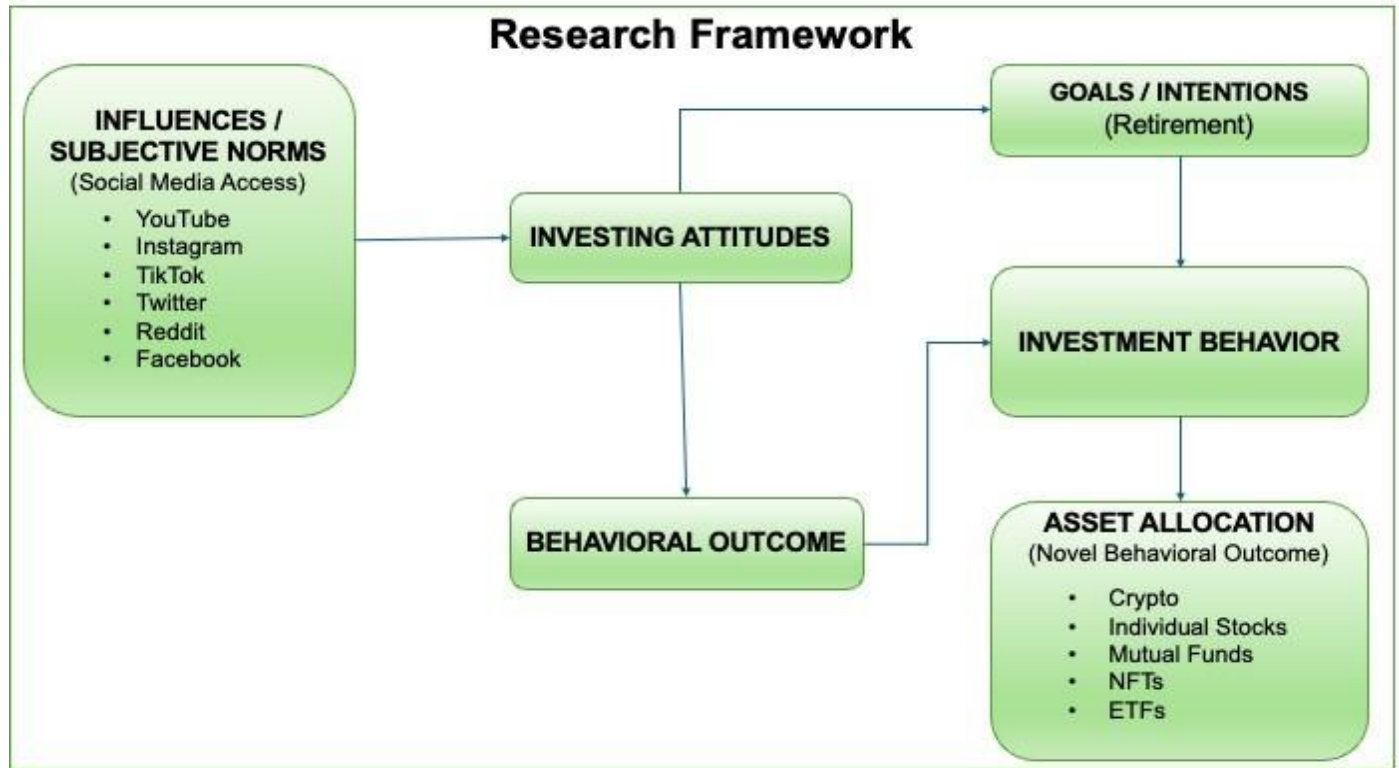
Demographic factors such as age, education, gender, and financial experience significantly influence how people perceive risk, make investment choices, and behave in financial markets. (Antwi & Naanwaab, 2022). The research conducted in the United States shows that individuals with higher education levels— such as college or postgraduate—are more likely to own financial securities than those education ends with only a high school diploma. Additionally, higher education is associated with a greater willingness to take risk, financial literacy and a greater propensity to participate in investment activities. (Yakoboski Lusardi & Sticha, 2025).

2.10 Investment Decision; Asset allocation:

The generational differences in investment preferences reveal distinct patterns across asset classes. Gen Z investors show a pronounced inclination toward emerging digital assets, with 55% investing in cryptocurrencies and 25% in NFTs, reflecting their comfort with technology and speculative instruments. Millennials also demonstrate strong engagement with crypto (57%) and NFTs (28%), though their participation in traditional vehicles like mutual funds (43%) and ETFs (26%) is notably higher than that of Gen Z. Gen X investors, in contrast, favor conventional investment products, with 47% investing in mutual funds and 43% in individual stocks, while their involvement in crypto (39%) and NFTs (15%) remains comparatively modest. These findings underscore the evolving landscape of investor behavior shaped by generational attitudes, technological familiarity, and risk tolerance. (CFA Institute & FINRA Investor Education Foundation, 2023).

A Nasdaq survey supports this trend, showing that 73% of Gen Z hold stocks, 47% invest in crypto-related stocks, 30% own bonds, and 15% are exposed to ETFs. This indicates a broader diversification, heavily tilted toward high-volatility assets like cryptocurrencies. From a technical perspective, younger investors are more willing to endure drawdowns for higher returns, often using momentum strategies and swing trading in crypto and tech stocks. (Nasdaq, 2025).

2.12 Research Framework



2.13 Variable Relationship

Relationship	Description
Influencing Factor → Attitude towards investing	How External factors shape investment attitude
Investing Attitudes → Investment goal/Intention	Positive or negative attitude increases Gen-Z investment goals or intentions
Goals/Intentions → Investment Behavior	Goals/ Intentions drive actual behavior of investing towards their retirement
Investment Behavior → Asset Allocation	Behavior determinates how assets are distributed-> Novel behavioral outcome

CHAPTER – 3

RESEARCH AND METHODOLOGY

3.1 Exploratory Research

The study employed an exploratory research methodology to gain a better understanding of Generation Z's financial behavior and investment decision-making process. In order to identify significant variables and collect data on important factors, a thorough survey was conducted. Hypotheses were then developed for additional empirical testing.

3.2 The Secondary Data's Background Investigation

The 2023 report “Gen-Z and investing: social media, crypto, FOMO, and family,” which was released by the FINRA Investor Education Foundation and the CFA Institute, provided the secondary data for this study. The original study polled 2872 participants from various nations and generations, including a national sample of Gen-Zers in the United States. Although the original report was made public, region-specific data for the southern United States, which were directly obtained from FINRA upon request, were used to analyze the financial behavior of Generation Z. This dataset makes it possible to thoroughly investigate whether the Southern regional context reflects the behavior patterns and influencing factors found at the national level.

3.3 Descriptive Research

Data for this study were collected during the months of November and December 2022. Participants were recruited through a combined approach that included Schlesinger's proprietary online panel, which is a curated database of potential survey respondents, and targeted social media advertising campaigns on TikTok and Instagram, designed to reach diverse demographic groups. Individuals who agreed to

participate in the study completed online surveys and received monetary compensation as an incentive. Although Generation Z is generally characterized as individuals born between 1997 and 2012, this study specifically focused on participants aged 18 to 25 years old to target young adults within the cohort. U.S. participants were selected to ensure a balanced representation across key demographic variables—such as age, geographic region, race and ethnicity, and gender—based on data from the five-year rolling averages provided by the American Community Survey.

3.4 Survey Questionnaire

A structured questionnaire was employed as the primary research method in this study to gather quantitative data efficiently. The survey was administered in English to ensure consistency in responses across diverse participant backgrounds. Participants were carefully selected using judgmental sampling, a non-probability technique that involves selecting individuals based on specific expertise or characteristics relevant to the study's context. The development of the questionnaire was grounded in the theoretical framework of the Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB), which was used to identify relevant constructs and guide question formulation. The questionnaire comprised several primary following sections:

1. Goals → Intentions
2. Investing Attitudes → Attitude
3. Influence → Subjective Norm
4. Investing/non-investors → Actual Behaviors
5. Demographic

Each is tailored to explore different facets of the TPB model in relation to the studied behavior.

3.5 Sampling Plan

The online survey received 342 responses from a mix of investors and non-investors across the Southern region of the United States. For the analysis, we focused exclusively on 172 Generation Z respondents who identified themselves as investors. Further details regarding the sample selection criteria and data validation procedures are provided in the Data Analysis section.

3.6 Scoring and Categorization of responses

The FINRA and CFA Institute (2023) reported that the pilot test was conducted. The use of structured 1-5 Likert-scale survey questions, like "strongly disagree, disagree, neutral, agree, strongly agree," suggested that consistency and reliability, the instrument had likely been pretested or internal validation had been completed before the primary data collection.

In the present study, descriptive and inferential analyses were conducted, measurement and values were interpreted as follows:

The responses were converted into a five-point Likert scale for analysis.

The mean values were classified into $(1.00-2.33) = \text{low}$, $(2.34-3.66) = \text{moderate}$, and $(3.67-5.00) = \text{high}$ investment behavior. Similarly, standard deviation (SD) values were classified into $(0.00-1.00) = \text{low}$, $(1.01-1.50) = \text{moderate}$ and $(1.51-2.00) = \text{high}$

A Spearman's rank-order correlation (ρ) was conducted to examine the relationships between the variables of Influence factor, Goal, investing attitude, Investing Behavior and asset allocation because the data were measured on ordinal Likert scales and did not meet normality assumptions (Spearman, C. 1904). Spearman's rho has a range of -1 to $+1$, where a positive value means that when one variable rises, the other also tends to rise; a negative value means that when one variable rises, the other tends to fall; and a value of 0 means that there is no correlation between the variables. The

strength of the relationship is interpreted based on the absolute value of ρ , with values closer to 1 or -1 indicating a stronger association.

In this study, a hypothesis was considered accepted if Spearman's p -value (2-tailed) was less than or equal to 0.05, which means the result is statistically significant (Spearman, C. 1904).

3.6 Sampling Selection Criteria

1. Population of interest: Generation Z typically aged 18-25
2. Geographical scope: Respondents are selected from the Southern region of the United States.

CHAPTER - 4

DATA ANALYSIS AND RESULT

Initial data preparation was carried out in Python version 3, where the raw data were converted into CSV format and randomized coding alignment was performed to standardize variable labels and ordering. The resulting CSV file was then reviewed and cleaned in Microsoft Excel. After finalizing the dataset, statistical analyses were conducted using SPSS Version 31.0.1.0.

The original survey had 342 people who took part, including both investors and non-investors. The reported percentages for investors and non-investors were 99% and 98%, but these numbers overlapped and didn't add up to 100%. To make sure the numbers were accurate and added up to 100%, they were adjusted proportionally. This changed the numbers to 172 investors (50.3%) and 170 non-investors (49.7%).

Since this study is only about attitudes and behaviors related to investing, only the group of investors ($n = 172$) was used for the analysis.

The breakdown of the investor group by demographics was calculated by multiplying the total number of investors by the percentages for each demographic category. Some small rounding changes were made to ensure the numbers added up correctly. For example, based on the gender split (58% men, 41% women), the final numbers were 101 male investors (58.6%) and 71 female investors (41.4%).

All the analyses were done using the investor group, and the non-investor data were only used in summary form to give context about the overall survey.

The study looks at factors like age, gender, income, and education that relate to behavior and personal characteristics. But it did not include information about race or Hispanic origin in the data set to keep people's identities private and avoid any ethical problems that might come from sharing sensitive personal details.

Table 4.1 Demographic profile

	Frequency	Investor percentage
Gender		
Men	101	58.6%
Women	71	41.4%
Age		
18-19	34	20%
20-22	79	46%
23-25	58	34%
Education		
High school or less	40	23%
Attending college or some college	60	35%
College grad or more	72	42%
Household income		
< \$ 30,000	27	16%
\$ 30,000 - \$ 75000	57	33%
\$ 75000 +	88	51%

Table 4.2 Theory planned behavior model construct (N=172)

TPB construct	Indicator Variable from FINRA data	Percentage of Generation Z	Interpretation
Investing Attitude	Willing to take above average or substantial financial risk	46%	It shows that positive risk-taking attitude
Goal (Intention)	Retirement as a primary financial Goal	51%	Retirement planning reflects long-term financial goal

Influence Factor (Subjective Norm)	Learned about investment via social media	48%	Social media influences their way of investing
Actual Investment Behavior	Currently Invests	56%	U.S Generation Z report owning at least some investments.

Table 4.3 Descriptive Statistics of Investment Variables

Descriptive Statistics					
	N	Minimum	Maximum	Mean	Std. Deviation
Goal	172	1	5	2.72	1.395
Attitude	172	1	5	2.55	1.399
Influence	172	1	5	2.85	1.417
Behavior	172	1	5	2.89	1.437
Valid N (listwise)	172				

Table 4.3 Descriptive statistics were computed for the main study variables using a sample size of 172 respondents ($n = 172$). The results showed that Goal ($M = 2.72$, $SD = 1.395$), Attitude ($M = 2.55$, $SD = 1.399$), Influence ($M = 2.85$, $SD = 1.417$), and Investment Behavior ($M = 2.89$, $SD = 1.437$) all fell within the expected 1–5 Likert-scale range. The distribution of minimum and maximum scores indicated adequate variability across all four constructs, supporting their suitability for further statistical analysis.

4.4 Table: Spearman Rank Correlation of Investment Variables

Correlations						
			Goal	Attitude	Influence	Behavior
Spearman's rho	Goal	Correlation Coefficient	1.000	.120	-.058	-.005
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.	.117	.451	.951
		N	172	172	172	172
	Attitude	Correlation Coefficient	.120	1.000	-.053	-.133
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.117	.	.488	.082
		N	172	172	172	172
	Influence	Correlation Coefficient	-.058	-.053	1.000	.081
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.451	.488	.	.292
		N	172	172	172	172
	Behavior	Correlation Coefficient	-.005	-.133	.081	1.000
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.951	.082	.292	.
		N	172	172	172	172

Spearman's rho Correlations

-  **Highly Positive:** (None)
 -  **Positive:** (Goal <---> Attitude), (Influence <---> Behavior)
 -  **No Linear Correlation:** (None)
 -  **Negative:** (Goal <---> Influence), (Goal <---> Behavior), (Attitude <---> Influence), (Attitude <---> Behavior)
 -  **Highly Negative:** (None)
- Note: Curated Help is calculated based on actual cell values, not the formatted values.

4.5 Investment Behavior → Asset allocation (Novel behavioral outcome)

Variables	Percentage of Generation Z
Crypto	55%
Stocks	41%
Mutual Funds	35%
NFTs	25%
EFTs	23%
Investment Behavior	56%

4.6 Table: Descriptive Statistics of Investment Behavior and Assets

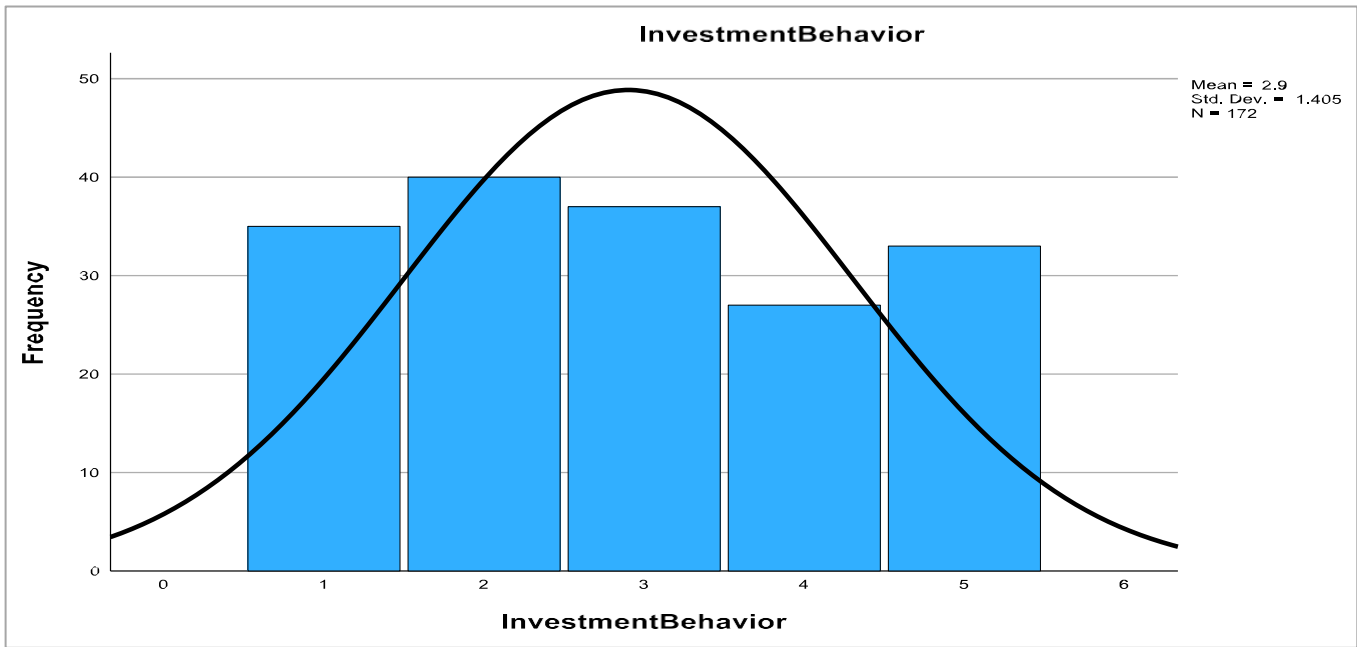
	Descriptive Statistics					
	N	Minimum	Maximum	Missing	Mean	Std. Deviation
Investment Behavior	172	1	5	0	2.90	1.405
Crypto	172	1	5	0	2.78	1.409
Stocks	172	1	5	0	2.54	1.476
Mutual Funds	172	1	5	0	2.31	1.272
NFTs	172	1	5	0	2.06	1.253
ETFs	172	1	5	0	2.18	1.217
Valid N (listwise)	172					

Table 4.6 This table summarizes descriptive statistics for 172 respondents, examining their investment behavior across five asset types—Crypto, Stocks, Mutual Funds, NFTs, and ETFs—using a 1 to 5 scale. The overall investment behavior has a mean of 2.90 and a standard deviation of 1.405, indicating moderate engagement with noticeable variability. Among asset types, Crypto (mean = 2.78) and Stocks (mean = 2.54) show relatively higher interest, with Stocks having the highest variability (SD = 1.476), suggesting diverse attitudes. Mutual Funds (mean = 2.31), ETFs (mean = 2.18), and NFTs (mean = 2.06) reflect lower average interest, with tighter clustering around their means. All categories have complete data with no missing values, and the spread of standard deviations across assets points to significant individual differences in investment preferences.

4.7 Table: Investment Behavior

Investment Behavior					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	1	35	20.3	20.3	20.3
	2	40	23.3	23.3	43.6
	3	37	21.5	21.5	65.1
	4	27	15.7	15.7	80.8
	5	33	19.2	19.2	100.0
	Total	172	100.0	100.0	

Figure – 4.7

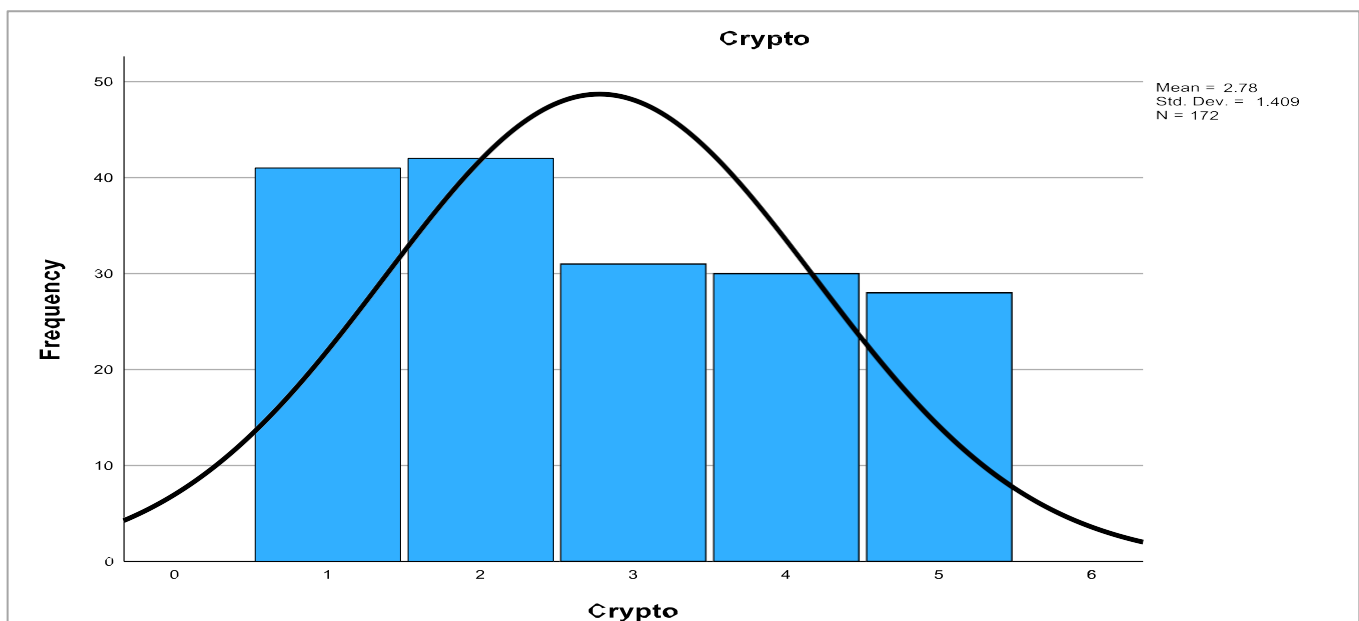


The table and figure 4.7 illustrate the Investment Behavior scale indicate that most participants chose the middle values, with the average score being **2.9** out of 5. This means that, overall, respondents show a **moderate level of investment behavior**. The graph also shows that the numbers are fairly balanced across the scale, with fewer people choosing the very low (1) or very high (5) options. Overall, the responses follow a smooth, almost normal pattern.

4.8 Table: Crypto

Crypto					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	1	41	23.8	23.8	23.8
	2	42	24.4	24.4	48.3
	3	31	18.0	18.0	66.3
	4	30	17.4	17.4	83.7
	5	28	16.3	16.3	100.0
	Total	172	100.0	100.0	

Figure – 4.8



The table and Figure 4.8 illustrating the distribution of the Crypto variable among 172 respondents. The the largest groups selected ratings 1 and 2, each with 41 (23.8%) and 42(24.4%) responses respectively, while higher ratings (3, 4, and 5) show a gradual decline in frequency. The overlaid normal curve suggests a slightly left-skewed distribution, indicating that more respondents provided lower ratings. The descriptive statistics shown on the graph report a mean of 2.78 and a standard deviation of 1.499, reflecting **moderate variability** in responses.

4.9 Table: Stocks

Stocks					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	1	56	32.6	32.6	32.6
	2	47	27.3	27.3	59.9
	3	18	10.5	10.5	70.3
	4	22	12.8	12.8	83.1
	5	29	16.9	16.9	100.0
	Total	172	100.0	100.0	

Figure – 4.9

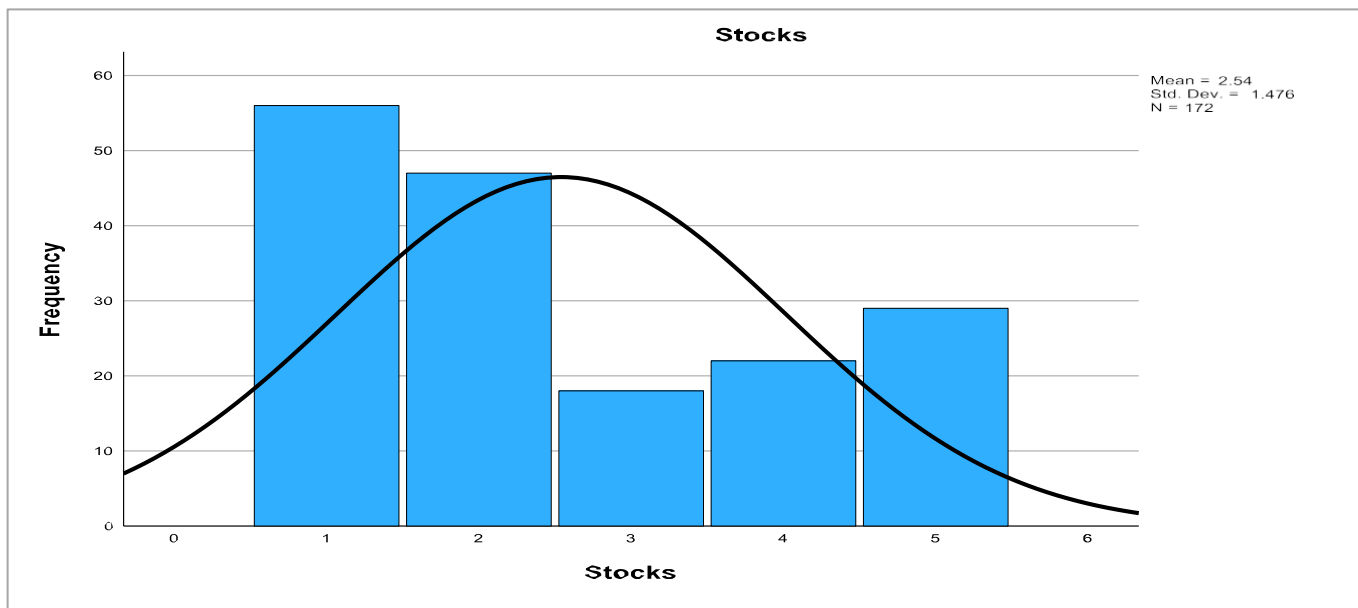
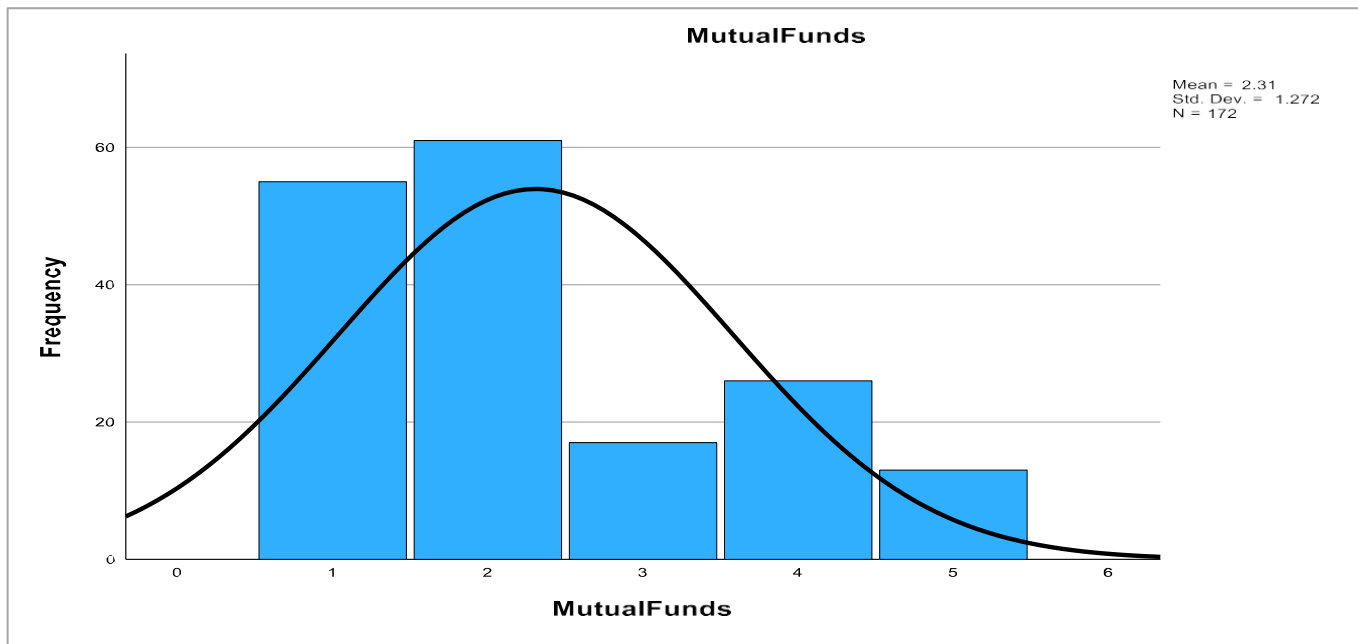


Figure 4.9 based on a 5-point Likert scale, shows that most respondents reported lower stock investment levels, with 56 participants (32.6%) and 47 participants (27.3%), totaling nearly 60% of the sample. Mid-range responses were less frequent, with 18 (10.5%) and 22 (12.8%), while 29 respondents (16.9%) selected the highest level. The right-skewed histogram reflects this distribution, and the mean of 2.54 indicates generally lower investment levels, with a standard deviation of 1.476 showing **moderate variability**.

4.10 Table: Mutual Fund

Mutual Funds					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	1	55	32.0	32.0	32.0
	2	61	35.5	35.5	67.4
	3	17	9.9	9.9	77.3
	4	26	15.1	15.1	92.4
	5	13	7.6	7.6	100.0
	Total	172	100.0	100.0	

Figure – 4.10

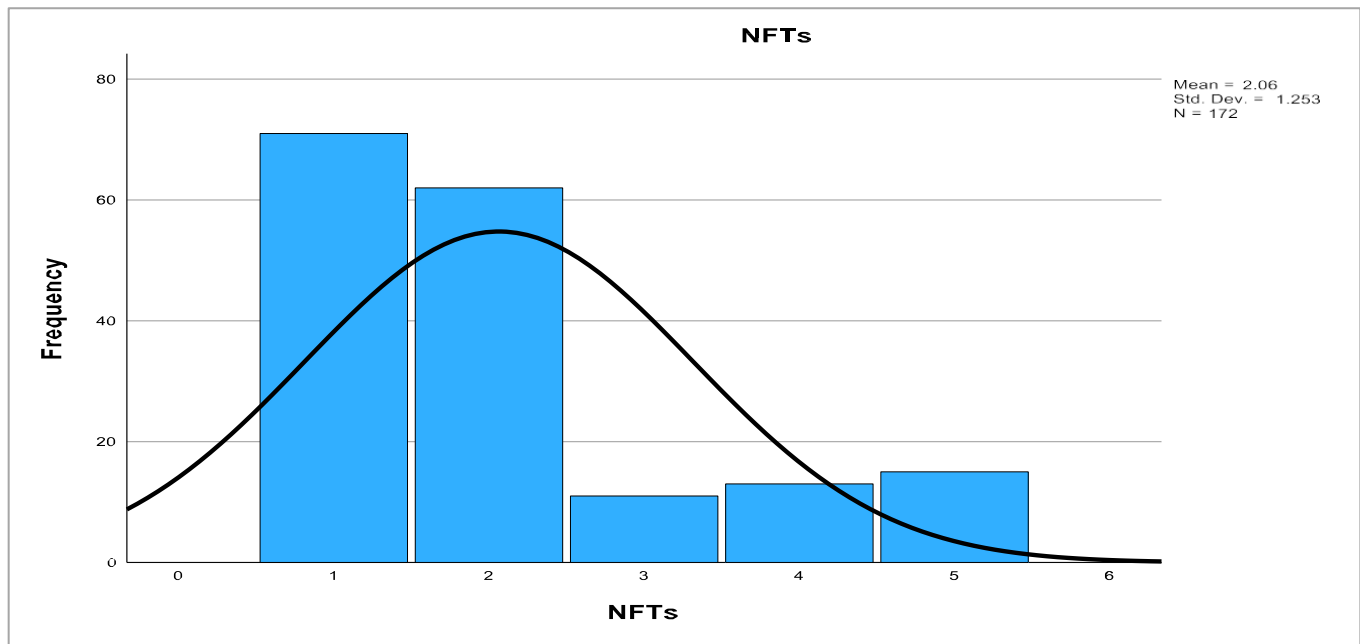


The table and figure 4.10 present the distribution of respondents' ratings of mutual fund involvement on a 1–5 Likert scale, showing that most participants selected the lower levels. Level 1 accounts for 32% of responses and level 2 for 35.5%, while higher levels appear less frequently, with only 7.6% choosing level 5. The bar chart, overlaid with a normal curve, reflects this pattern visually and corresponds to a mean score of 2.31 and a standard deviation of 1.272 across 172 respondents, indicating generally low to **moderate engagement** with mutual funds.

4.11 Table: NFTs

NFTs					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
	1	71	41.3	41.3	41.3
	2	62	36.0	36.0	77.3
	3	11	6.4	6.4	83.7
	4	13	7.6	7.6	91.3
	5	15	8.7	8.7	100.0
	Total	172	100.0	100.0	

Figure – 4.11

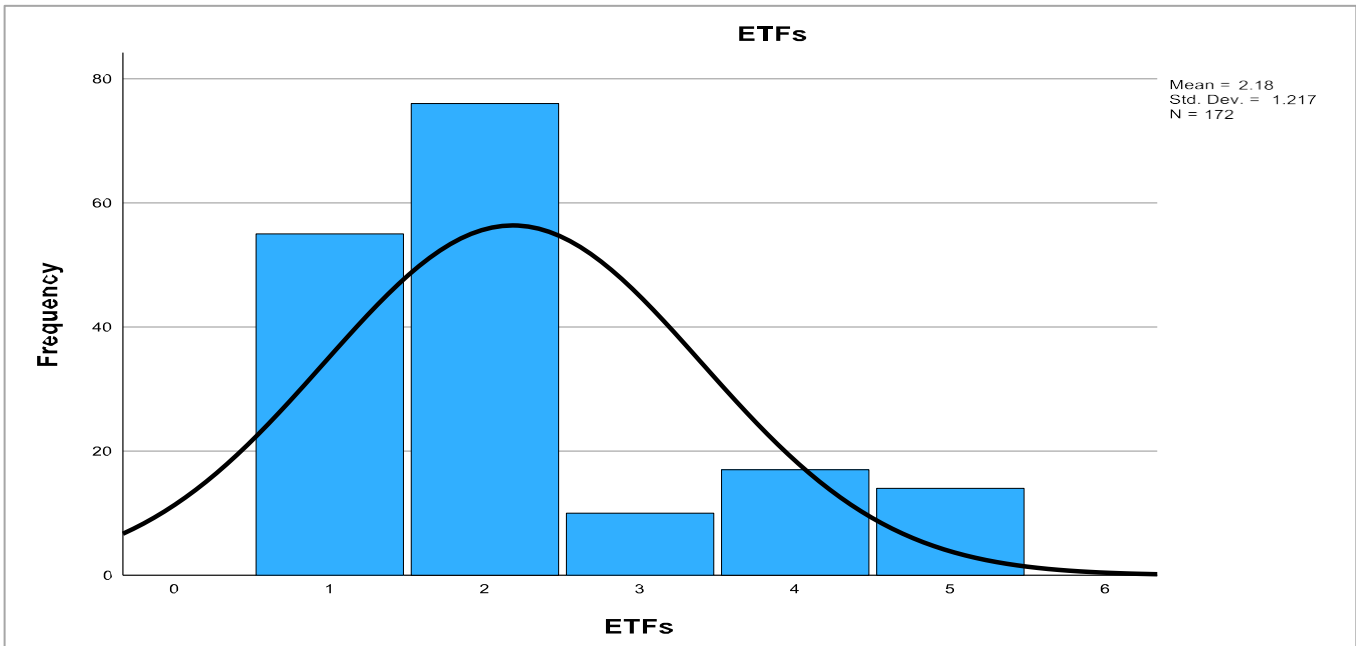


The table and figure 4.11 shows that how respondents are distributed across that scale. Most participants selected lower values, with 41.3% choosing 1 and 36.0% choosing 2, indicating a tendency toward minimal engagement or lower agreement. Higher values (4 and 5) were chosen by fewer respondents (7.6% and 8.7%, respectively), suggesting that strong endorsement or high involvement is less common. The mean score of 2.06 and standard deviation of 1.253 reinforce this skew toward the lower end of the scale.

4.12 Table: ETFs

ETFs					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	1	55	32.0	32.0	32.0
	2	76	44.2	44.2	76.2
	3	10	5.8	5.8	82.0
	4	17	9.9	9.9	91.9
	5	14	8.1	8.1	100.0
	Total	172	100.0	100.0	

Figure – 4.12



The table and histogram 4.12 present the distribution of respondents’ Likert-scale ratings (1–5) regarding their views or involvement with ETFs. Among the 172 participants, the most frequent rating is 2 (44.2%), followed by 1 (32%), showing that respondents generally lean toward the lower end of the scale. Ratings of 3 (5.8%), 4 (9.9%), and 5 (8.1%) are comparatively less common, indicating fewer respondents expressed neutral or highly positive views. The histogram mirrors this pattern, with higher bars at the lower scale points and a clear decline as ratings increase, creating a

right-skewed distribution. The overall mean rating of 2.18 (SD = 1.217) suggests that participants' perceptions or engagement with ETFs tend to be below the midpoint of the scale.

4.13 Table: Spearman Rank Correlation of Investment Behavior and Assets

Correlations								
			Investment Behavior	Crypto	Stocks	Mutual Funds	NFTs	ETFs
Spearman's rho	Investment Behavior	Correlation Coefficient	1.000	.036	-.043	-.094	-.162*	.110
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.	.641	.573	.218	.034	.151
		N	172	172	172	172	172	172
	Crypto	Correlation Coefficient	.036	1.000	-.031	-.116	-.075	.147
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.641	.	.687	.129	.331	.054
		N	172	172	172	172	172	172
	Stocks	Correlation Coefficient	-.043	-.031	1.000	.049	.044	.181*
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.573	.687	.	.522	.570	.017
		N	172	172	172	172	172	172
	Mutual Funds	Correlation Coefficient	-.094	-.116	.049	1.000	-.036	.054
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.218	.129	.522	.	.643	.485
		N	172	172	172	172	172	172
	NFTs	Correlation Coefficient	-.162*	-.075	.044	-.036	1.000	.014
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.034	.331	.570	.643	.	.853
		N	172	172	172	172	172	172
	ETFs	Correlation Coefficient	.110	.147	.181*	.054	.014	1.000
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.151	.054	.017	.485	.853	.
		N	172	172	172	172	172	172

*. Correlation is significant at the 0.05 level (2-tailed).

Spearman's rho Correlations

 **Highly Positive:** (None)

 **Positive:** (Investment Behavior <---> Crypto), (Investment Behavior <---> ETFs), (Crypto <---> ETFs), (Stocks <---> Mutual Funds), (Stocks <---> NFTs), (Stocks <---> ETFs), (Mutual Funds <---> ETFs), (NFTs <---> ETFs)

 **No Linear Correlation:** (None)

 **Negative:** (Investment Behavior <---> Stocks), (Investment Behavior <---> Mutual Funds), (Investment Behavior <---> NFTs), (Crypto <---> Stocks), (Crypto <---> Mutual Funds), (Crypto <---> NFTs), (Mutual Funds <---> NFTs)

 **Highly Negative:** (None) Note: Curated Help is calculated based on actual cell values, not the formatted values.

CHAPTER - 5

FINDINGS

This Section presents the findings of the study that focusing on financial behaviors and asset allocation of 172 Generation Z participants from the southern region of United States.

1. H_1 - Investing Attitude and Goal indicated a positive correlation ($\rho=.120$); However, the relationship was not statistically significant (2-tailed $P=.117$) H_1 is not supported.
2. H_2 - Investing Attitude and Actual Investment Behavior showed a negative correlation ($\rho= -.133$); The relationship was not statistically significant (2-tailed $P= .082$) H_2 is not supported.
3. H_3 - Influencing Factors and Investing Attitude indicated a negative correlation ($\rho= -.053$); However, there was no significant relationship (2-tailed $P= .488$) so H_3 not supported.
4. H_4 - Influencing factors and investing behavior indicated a positive correlation ($\rho= .081$); The relationship was not statistically significant (2-tailed $p= .292$) H_4 is not supported.
5. H_5 - Goal and Actual Investment Behavior showed a negative correlation ($\rho= -.005$); There was no significant relationship has found (2-tailed $P= .951$) H_5 is not supported.
6. H_6 - Investment Behavior and Asset Allocation indicated
 - Crypto ($\rho=.036$, positive, $P=.641$ not significant)
 - Stocks ($\rho= -.043$ negative, $P= .573$ not significant)
 - Mutual Fund ($\rho= -.094$, negative, $P= .218$ not significant)
 - NFTs, ($\rho= -.162$ negative, $P=.034$ Significant)
 - ETFs ($\rho= .110$ positive, $P=.151$ not significant).

Therefore, H_6 is partially accepted. Investment behavior has significant relationship with NFTs but not to Crypto, Stocks, Mutual fund, ETFs.

5.1 Discussion

1. The descriptive analysis results show that Generation Z investors have a moderate level of investment behavior. Cryptocurrency and stocks are more preferred investment options compared to mutual funds, NFTs, and ETFs. The variation in responses indicates diverse investment preferences among Gen Z investors. All four investment variables fall in the moderate range, meaning respondents show moderate financial goals, moderate investing attitude, moderate social-media influence, and moderate investing behavior.
2. The findings indicate that the goal of retirement has positively correlated with the investing attitude of Generation Z ($\rho=.120$, $P=.117$); however, the results showed that there is not any significant relationship. This may be because, as stated in FINRA 2023, Generation Z has different goals, such as travel and vacation or saving for unexpected expenses, which may be their main objective rather than the retirement goal.
3. Investing behavior and investing attitude ($\rho= -.133$, $P= .082$) have a negative correlation, meaning that one variable rises while the other falls and becomes insignificant. This may be because the investing attitude measures psychological perception, while the asset holding reflects an actual decision influenced by many external factors such as income, family responsibilities, and job security.
4. The influencing factor that is social media is negatively correlated with investment attitude ($\rho= -.053$, $P= .488$) and not having a significant relationship because Generation Z might trust the other sources for getting information to learn about investing, such as universities/colleges, financial companies, and financial professionals.
5. Influencing factor (social media) and investment behavior is positively correlated and insignificant ($\rho= .081$, $p= .292$). This lack of significance could be due to the

small sample size, high variability in investment choices, or the weak effect of social media on asset-holding behavior.

6. Goal and Investment Behavior—The retirement goal is negatively correlated and insignificant ($\rho = -.005$, $P = .951$). This may be because retirement is a long-term financial goal, whereas actual investment behavior often reflects short-term liquidity needs, risk tolerance, and market conditions. Therefore, the long-term nature of retirement planning may not directly translate into immediate investment participation, resulting in a non-significant relationship.
7. Investment behavior and asset allocation showed that there is not a significant relationship with crypto, stocks, mutual funds, or ETFs because participants may hold very small amounts of traditional assets, which reduces statistical variations and weakens the relationship, and ($P = .034$) having a strong bond with NFTs due to their popularity among younger, tech-savvy people.
8. According to the FINRA Foundation and CFA Institute 2023 national study, about **two in ten Gen Z investors (19 %) are currently invested in cryptocurrency and/or NFTs**. In this study, **NFT ownership showed a significant relationship with investment behavior**, whereas cryptocurrency did not. This suggests that, while a smaller proportion of Gen Z nationally invest in these digital assets, **NFTs may have a stronger influence on actual investment behavior in the Southern U.S.**, highlighting their potential role in shaping regional investment patterns consistent with broader national interest identified by FINRA.

5.2 Conclusion

This study examined the financial habits of Generation Z in the southern part of the United States, focusing on their financial goals, factors that influence their decisions, attitudes toward investing, actual investing behaviors, and how they distribute their assets. The research was conducted within the broader context of the extended Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB). It adds value to current knowledge by including asset allocation as a novel behavioral outcome, which opens up new possibilities for

future research. This provides a basis for understanding how intentions translate into real investment actions among young investors. The findings also provide useful guidance for financial educators, planners, and fintech companies aiming to better connect with Gen Z by tailoring their approaches to match the financial behaviors and preferences of this generation.

5.3 Research Contribution and Implications

This study contributes to the existing literature by applying the Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB) to examine the investment behavior and asset allocation patterns of Generation Z in the Southern United States, using both descriptive statistics and Spearman's non-parametric correlation analysis.

The study offers empirical data on the connections between important variables, such as asset allocation, financial objectives, investing attitude, influencing factors, and investing behavior. By incorporating asset allocation across both traditional and emerging asset classes (stocks, mutual funds, cryptocurrencies, ETFs, and NFTs) as a novel behavioral outcome, it expands the conventional TPB framework and provides a deeper understanding of investment decision-making.

The results also provide fresh empirical understanding of how TPB functions differently across different asset classes. The Traditional asset classes did not show statistically significant relationships, despite the fact that NFT investments showed significant associations, suggesting lower involvement or indirect participation among Southern U.S. Generation Z investors.

By focusing on Generation Z in the Southern United States, this study adds region-specific empirical evidence to the predominantly national and international literature on youth investment behavior, highlighting how local socio-economic and cultural contexts shape digital and emerging investment choices.

5.4 Societal Implications

1. The results show that Gen Z's investing choices are influenced by goals, attitudes, and social media, highlighting the need for better financial education to help young adults assess information, understand risk, and make informed decisions.
2. The study emphasizes the growing role of digital platforms in investment behavior, urging responsible online communication and clearer guidelines to prevent misinformation and risky advice.
3. The strong link between investment habits and asset allocation underlines the importance of tools promoting balanced, diversified portfolios to reduce exposure to volatile assets.
4. Gen Z's interest in cryptocurrencies and NFTs may affect market stability, requiring public awareness and policy measures for sustainable investing.
5. Policymakers can use these insights to create programs promoting long-term savings, retirement planning, and transparent digital investing, protecting young investors while encouraging market participation.
6. Financial firms can develop products with features like personalized guidance and educational content to help Gen Z navigate financial decisions confidently.
7. There's a cultural shift with younger generations relying more on peers and online communities for investing, necessitating new ways to share financial knowledge responsibly.
8. As Gen Z's investors grow, their behaviors will impact wealth distribution and economic resilience, so supporting informed investing can foster societal financial stability.

5.5 Suggestions

1. Investors should develop clear financial goals, as goal clarity reduces risky or impulsive decisions.
2. Financial advisors can provide guidance on asset allocation, helping investors make balanced decisions across crypto, stocks, ETFs, NFTs and mutual funds.
3. Awareness programs can improve investment attitude, especially for new investors.
4. Social media influence should be monitored, as it significantly shapes investment behavior.
5. Future researchers can explore asset allocation as a new behavioral outcome based on the TPB model, adding more asset categories.

5.6 Limitation of the study

While this study provides valuable insights into the investment preferences and financial behaviors of Generation Z, the several limitations must be acknowledged to ensure a balanced interpretation of findings.

1. Defining “Generation Z” varies across studies—some consider those born from 1997 to 2012, while others set different age ranges. This inconsistency can influence how results are interpreted, as younger Gen Z members, who are still students, might have different financial experiences compared to older members who are employed or entrepreneurs.
2. Most of the referenced data come from surveys and self-reported responses. Such methods are prone to response bias, as participants may overstate their financial literacy, investment knowledge, or level of participation in markets. This affects the accuracy and reliability of conclusions.
3. The study examined the relationship between investment behavior and only five asset allocation categories — crypto, stocks, mutual funds, NFTs, and ETFs. Other forms of investments such as real estate, gold, bonds, savings instruments, and

insurance were not included. Therefore, the findings may not represent the full range of investment choices made by individuals.

4. Gen Z investing behavior is highly influenced by technological and economic changes, such as new fintech platforms, crypto regulations, or social media trends. Since the financial landscape evolves quickly, findings based on 2023 –2025 data may not reflect future behaviors or attitudes accurately.

CHAPTER - 6

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ANNEXURE

QUESTIONNAIRE

SECTION 1: GOALS

Please take your time and answer questions carefully, as this research study will be used to help inform and educate the public about financial decision-making.

Q1. Select your financial goals from the list below. *Please choose all that apply.*

1. Save for education (mine or children's or grandchildren's)
2. Have sufficient savings to pay for unexpected expenses
3. Have enough money to travel/vacation
4. Not live from paycheck to paycheck – have money left over
5. Live independently from parents/relatives
6. Buy a home
7. Pay off/reduce credit card, auto, medical debt
8. Pay off/reduce my educational debt/loans
9. Pay off/reduce mortgage debt
10. Be able to pay monthly bills
11. Save enough to retire when I want to and live comfortably as long as I need to
12. Have a source of income outside of my job
13. Save enough to start a family
14. Save enough to start my own business
15. Buy a car
16. Buy real estate for investment purposes/passive income
17. Other, please specify:

Q2. How confident are you that you will be able to reach your financial goals?

1. Not at all confident
2. Not very confident
3. Somewhat confident
4. Very confident
5. Extremely confident

Q3. What are your top three challenges as you try to meet your financial goals?

Please select up to three.

1. Employment/income
2. Cost of living/inflation
3. Healthcare expenses or potential healthcare expenses
4. Educational loans/debt
5. Other debt (not education-related)
6. Cost of raising children
7. Unexpected expenses
8. Economy/market conditions
9. Lack of knowledge about finances/investing
10. Other, please specify:

SECTION 2: INFLUENCES

Q4. What information and resources have you used to learn about investing or other financial topics? Please select all that apply.

1. Parents/family
2. Friends
3. Social media
4. Websites or internet search results
5. School education
6. University/college education
7. Podcasts or blogs
8. Employer
9. Financial professional (advisor, accountant, etc.)

10. Influencers/experts/pundits
11. Financial app
12. Financial companies/institutions
13. Books, magazines, print media
14. Television
15. Government agencies or resources
16. Other, please specify:
17. None/have not learned about these topics

SKIP Q5 IF ONLY ONE ITEM SELECTED IN Q4 OR IF Q4=17.

Q5. Which resources do you trust most for learning about investing or other financial topics? Please select up to 3 that you trust most.

1. Parents/family
2. Friends
3. Social media
4. Websites or internet search results
5. School education
6. University/college education
7. Podcasts or blogs
8. Employer
9. Financial professional (advisor, accountant, etc.)
10. Influencers/experts/pundits
11. Financial app
12. Financial companies/institutions
13. Books, magazines, print media
14. Television
15. Government agencies or resources
16. Other, please specify:

Q6. Which social media or internet sites do you currently use to learn about investing or other financial topics? Please select all that apply.

1. Clubhouse
2. Discord
3. Facebook
4. Instagram
5. Internet search
6. Investopedia
7. LinkedIn
8. Reddit
9. Stocktwits
10. TikTok
11. Twitch
12. Twitter
13. YouTube
14. Other (please specify)
15. I no longer use any of these sites to learn about investing or other financial topics

Q7. How do you decide what specific people/influencers/sites/groups to trust when it comes to investing or other financial topics? Please select all that apply.

1. Comes up on the first page in searches
2. Is a verified account (e.g., blue checkmark)
3. Number of followers
4. Information they provide is relevant to your situation
5. Explains things clearly
6. Shares their own investments/financial performance
7. Isn't trying to sell something/doesn't have motive aside from sharing information
8. Has a background similar to your own/understands you
9. Recommended by someone you trust
10. Funny/entertaining
11. Other, please specify:

Q8. Do you conduct most of your investing/financial research on a computer (desktop/laptop), tablet, or phone?

1. Computer (desktop/laptop)
2. Tablet
3. Phone
4. Other
5. I don't do any investing/financial research

Q9. Have your parents ever had investments?

1. Yes
2. No
3. Do not know

Q10. Did or do your parents or other family members ever talk to you about investing?

1. Yes, starting before I was 18
2. Yes, but only after I became an adult
3. No
4. Do not recall

Q11. Have you ever received a gift (not an inheritance) from your parents or grandparents that was \$10,000 or more?

1. Yes
2. No
3. Do not know

Q12. Please indicate how much you agree or disagree with the following statements:

RANDOMIZE ORDER	Strongly disagree	Somewhat disagree	Neutral	Somewhat agree	Strongly agree	Do not know
a. I am more knowledgeable than my parents about investing	1	2	3	4	5	9
b. I know more than my parents about money management, in general	1	2	3	4	5	9
c. I am better than my parents at money management	1	2	3	4	5	9

Q13. Have you ever had any formal education or classes about financial topics or investing? Please select all that apply.

1. Yes, in school
2. Yes, in university/college
3. Yes, from a professional body/industry association
4. Yes, from my employer
5. Yes, other
6. No

SECTION 3: INVESTING

Q14. What is the approximate total value of all your investments?

1. Mutual funds
2. ETFs (exchange-traded funds)
3. Individual company stocks
4. Individual company bonds
5. Municipal bonds
6. Government bonds
7. Cryptocurrency (e.g., Bitcoin, etc.)
8. NFTs (non-fungible tokens)
9. REITs (Real Estate Investment Trusts)
10. Alternative investments (e.g., gold, hedge funds, etc.)
11. Something else, please specify

Total Investments: \$_____.

Q15. What is the approximate total value of the crypto you own?

Q16. At about what age did you start investing? _____

Q17. And what type of investment(s) did you first start out with? Please select all that apply.

1. Mutual funds
2. ETFs (exchange-traded funds)
3. Individual company stocks
4. Individual company bonds
5. Municipal bonds
6. Government bonds
7. Cryptocurrency (e.g., Bitcoin, etc.)
8. NFTs (non-fungible tokens)
9. REITs (Real Estate Investment Trust)
10. Alternative investments (e.g., gold, hedge funds, etc.)
11. Something else, please specify

Q18. How much of a factor was each of the following in your decision to start investing?

RANDOMIZE ORDER	Not at all a factor				A major factor
	1	2	3	4	5
a. Parent or other family member	1	2	3	4	5
b. Friend or colleague	1	2	3	4	5
c. Teacher/professor	1	2	3	4	5
d. Curiosity or interest I had on my own	1	2	3	4	5
e. Online discussion board	1	2	3	4	5
f. Social media influencer, expert, or pundit	1	2	3	4	5
g. My employer	1	2	3	4	5
h. Fear of missing out (FOMO) on potential opportunities to grow my money	1	2	3	4	5
i. Obtained money to invest	1	2	3	4	5
j. Advertisement or push notification/message through an app of any kind	1	2	3	4	5
k. The ability to start investing with small amounts of money	1	2	3	4	5
l. Ease of opening an investment account	1	2	3	4	5
m. A promotional incentive to start investing, such as a cash incentive, cryptocurrency, or share of stock	1	2	3	4	5

Q19. How do you typically manage your investments and/or make trades?

1. Contact a specific financial professional
2. Call financial firm and use an available representative
3. Automate investing through a robo-advisor
4. Use a financial website or portal
5. Use investing app(s)
6. Other, please specify:

Q20. Do the investing apps you use ever make suggestions or provide information about a particular investment or strategy?

1. Yes
2. No
3. Do not know

Q21. Has a suggestion or message from an investing app ever influenced you to make a particular investment, trade, or purchase?

1. Yes
2. No
3. Do not know

Q22. What was the primary way you found your current financial professional?

Please choose one.

1. Use financial professional who worked with my parent(s) or other family member
2. Referral from a friend or colleague
3. The financial professional is a friend or family member
4. Searched online
5. Attended a seminar or webinar given by the financial professional
6. Went to a specific financial firm (call, website, in person) to look for a financial professional
7. Through my employer
8. An advertisement
9. Other, please specify

Q23. What is the primary reason you don't use a financial professional? Please choose one.

1. I don't have enough money invested to make it worthwhile
2. I am knowledgeable enough to do it on my own
3. I enjoy doing it on my own
4. I don't want to pay fees to a financial professional
5. Too expensive/I can't afford to work with a financial professional
6. I don't trust a financial professional to act in my best interest
7. I think that working with a financial professional might slow the process of making investment decisions
8. I do not know where/how to find a financial professional
9. Other, please specify:

Q24. How often do you do each of the following?

RANDOMIZE ORDER	Less than once a month	About once or twice a month	About once a week	A few times a week	About once a day	Multiple times a day
a. Monitor your investments, including checking the current value	1	2	3	4	5	6
b. Buy, trade, or change investments	1	2	3	4	5	6

Q25. Have you ever made a specific investment because of FOMO (Fear of Missing Out) on a potentially valuable investment?

1. Yes
2. No

Q26. What were the investments you made due to fear of missing out or FOMO? Please select all that apply.

1. Cryptocurrency
2. NFTs
3. Specific individual stocks, other than so-called "meme" stocks
4. Meme stocks (stocks that have gained an extremely popular following online or through social media)
5. Real estate
6. Other

Q27. Have you ever invested on margin?

1. Yes
2. No
3. I do not know what “investing on margin” is

SECTION 4: NON-INVESTORS

Q28. How much of a factor is each of the following in why you do not currently invest?

	Not at all a factor				A major factor
a. Not enough income/living paycheck to paycheck	1	2	3	4	5
b. I don't have enough knowledge about investing	1	2	3	4	5
c. I haven't taken the time to start	1	2	3	4	5
d. Not having a financial professional to work with	1	2	3	4	5
e. I don't have enough savings	1	2	3	4	5
f. I don't want to take the risk	1	2	3	4	5
g. I am focused on saving for other expenses (to buy a home, pay for kids' college, etc.)	1	2	3	4	5
h. I am focused on paying off debt	1	2	3	4	5

Q29. How likely are you to start investing in the next five years?

1. Not at all likely
2. Not very likely
3. Somewhat likely
4. Very likely
5. Extremely likely
6. Do not know

SECTION 5: INVESTING ATTITUDES

Q30. How confident are you in your ability to make decisions about investing?

1. Not at all confident
2. Not very confident
3. Somewhat confident
4. Very confident
5. Extremely confident

Q31. How likely are you to purchase each of the following investments in the future? If you aren't familiar with an investment, please select that option.

RANDOMIZE	Not at all likely	Not very likely	Somewhat likely	Very likely	Extremely likely	Not familiar with it
a. Mutual funds	1	2	3	4	5	6
b. ETFs (exchange-traded funds)	1	2	3	4	5	6
c. Stocks	1	2	3	4	5	6
d. Cryptocurrency	1	2	3	4	5	6
e. Bonds	1	2	3	4	5	6
f. Options or derivatives	1	2	3	4	5	6

Q32. In general, how risky do you think the following types of investments are?

	Not at all risky				Very risky	Do not know
a. Mutual funds	1	2	3	4	5	6
b. ETFs (exchange-traded funds)	1	2	3	4	5	6
c. Stocks	1	2	3	4	5	6
d. Cryptocurrency	1	2	3	4	5	6
e. Bonds	1	2	3	4	5	6
f. Options or derivatives	1	2	3	4	5	6

Q33. Which of the following statements comes closest to describing the amount of financial risk that you are willing to take when you save or make investments? *Please select one.*

1. Take substantial financial risks expecting to earn substantial returns
2. Take above average financial risks expecting to earn above average returns
3. Take average financial risks expecting to earn average returns
4. Take below average financial risks expecting to earn below average returns
5. Not willing to take any financial risks
6. Do not know

Q34. How strongly do you agree or disagree with the following statements?

RANDOMIZE	Strongly disagree			Neither agree nor disagree			Strongly agree
a. I am worried about losing money due to investment fraud	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
b. The economic circumstances facing my generation are more challenging than those of previous generations	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
c. To reach my financial goals, I need to take substantial risks in investing	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
d. I need to take more risks in my investments to meet my financial goals than older generations did when they were my age	1	2	3	4	5	6	7

SECTION 6: DEMOS

D1. Which of the following best describes your current employment situation?

Please select one.

1. Business owner/Self-employed
2. Employed full-time
3. Employed part-time
4. Employed as a homemaker
5. Not currently employed
6. Retired
7. Student
8. Other

D2. At what age do you expect to retire? If you don't know or think you will not retire, please use one of the check boxes below.

____ (retirement age)

- ☐ I do not want to ever retire – I prefer to keep working
- ☐ I will never be able to afford to retire
- ☐ Do not know

D3. Which of the following best describes your household/living situation?

1. Living alone
2. Living with partner/spouse
3. Living with parents and/or other relatives
4. Living with roommate(s)
5. Living at university most of the year
6. Other

D4. Do you currently own your home?

1. Yes
2. No

D5. How many children are financially dependent on you?

1. 1
2. 2
3. 3
4. 4 or more
5. Do not have any children
6. Do not have financially dependent children
7. Prefer not to say

D6. Which of the following categories best describes your highest level of education? Please select one.

1. Some high school/secondary school
2. High school/secondary school graduate or equivalent
3. Currently attending university
4. Some university but left without degree
5. University degree
6. Currently pursuing an advanced degree
7. Advanced degree

D7. Are you a financial advisor, financial planner, or investment professional?

1. Yes
2. No

D8. What is your personal annual income/salary (for you only, not including others in your household)? If you have no income, enter a zero.

Personal income: \$ _____ RANGE: \$0-\$9,999,999 or prefer not to say.

D9. Which of the following best describes the location of your primary residence?

1. Urban
2. Suburban
3. Rural